within this new city. Lorde represents Berlin as an alluring and bewildering domestic space within which she experiences both estrangement and comfort. Lorde conjures Berlin as neither an open city nor limited to just east or west. Against the backdrop of Lorde's professorship and exploration of Berlin, her first poem focuses on subtle observations, urban rhythms, and German turns of phrase that catch her attention.

She closes the poem with stories outside in the city, alluding to women she meets and how she moves with and around them as she navigates the city. The women in this poem are not sought here for simple solidarity or generative dialogue. They allow Lorde to hide, a form of restraint not usually attributed to a poet known for her outspoken nature and coalitional thinking in Germany.[36]

In her drafts of "First Impressions," she experiments with the placement of a refrain locating herself "in Berlin" to bridge and blur distinct observations between the lines of the poem. For example, the phrase does not appear as the ending line of her untitled journal version that provided the initial lines for this poem. She added the phrase two weeks later to the final line of the poem when she first typed up the work. This first typed draft includes the refrain on its own line at the end of the poem, only to be crossed out in a handwritten edit. The next draft and the final unmarked version retain the phrase, though she removes the line break and joins the final two lines with modified wording,[37] functioning as what Amitai F. Avi-Ram refers in relation to Lorde's work as an "apo koinou," a word or phrase that through enjambment shares meaning between two lines.[38] Whether the handwritten edits on the typed-out drafts are Lorde's or another reader's, the poet's questioning of how to deal with being in the city stands out. Lorde mined the physical and cultural makeup of the divided city as a surface of reflection and turned to poetry as an outlet to consider such observations. The fact that this poem remains unpublished, while much of her other writing about Berlin was prominently revised and published, reemphasizes the productive tension between Lorde's site-specific prolific output and purposeful exile in the divided city.

Outside of this early poem, Lorde also explored the complex landscape of the city, moving between public spaces of reflection and her own intimate sites. While clearly evinced in her poetry, a cache of photographic snapshots taken on the trip also lays bare these dynamics of public inquiry and personal refuge. Most of the photographs were taken within or at the edges